Planning & Research Document

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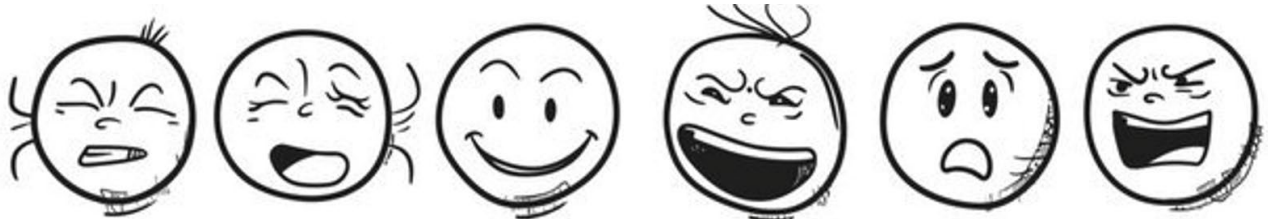


1. Project Overview

This project involves the creation of a series of **short 2D character-based animated clips** (10–15 seconds each), designed for viewing on social media platforms such as TikTok and Instagram Reels. The project focuses on visual storytelling and emotional expression through a single recurring original character.
The aim of the project is to explore how concise animation and character performance can communicate relatable everyday moments within a limited time frame. The project adopts a practical, industry-relevant approach to short-form animation commonly used in contemporary digital media and online content creation.

2. Platform Choice

A social media–focused platform was selected for this project, specifically **TikTok and Instagram Reels**, due to their emphasis on short-form, vertically oriented video content. These platforms are widely used for character-based animation and visual storytelling and are well suited to 10–15 second animated clips.
Designing for mobile-first viewing ensures that the animations prioritise clarity, readability, and emotional impact within a compact and accessible format.

3. Tools & Software Stack

The project will be developed using the following tools:

Adobe After Effects – for 2D character animation and motion design
Adobe Photoshop and/or Illustrator – for the creation of character assets and visual elements
Standard video export formats (9:16) – optimised for social media platforms
This workflow supports efficient production of short animations while allowing precise control over timing, expression, and visual style.

4. Research: Existing Systems / Similar Projects

Research for this project focuses on existing examples of **short-form character animation for social media**, including animated clips commonly found on TikTok and Instagram Reels.
These projects often rely on strong character design, expressive motion, and simple narrative structure to convey emotion quickly and effectively.
The research examines:

- pacing and timing in 10–15 second animations
- visual clarity on mobile devices
- the use of recurring characters to build familiarity and engagement

This research informs both the narrative structure and animation approach used in the project.

5. Proposed Project Structure / Flow

The project will consist of a **small series of short animated scenes**, each presenting a self-contained emotional moment involving the same recurring character. Each animation functions independently while contributing to a consistent overall style and narrative tone.
The general structure of each clip includes:

- a clear beginning (introduction of the moment)
- a central action or emotional beat
- a simple resolution or pause

This structure supports clear visual storytelling within a limited duration.

6. Project Plan & Timeline

Week 1 — Proposal & Initial Planning

Submission of Project Proposal
Finalisation of project theme and format
Identification of target platforms
Project diary setup

Deliverables:

Approved proposal
Diary: Week 1

Week 2 — Research & Planning

Research into short-form animation and social media storytelling
Analysis of similar character-based animations
Finalisation of tools and workflow

Deliverables:

Planning & Research document (draft)
Diary: Week 2

Week 3 — Character Development

Finalisation of character design and style
Development of emotional range and key poses
Preparation of layered character assets

Deliverables:

Character design sheets
Diary: Week 3

Week 4 — Storyboard & Scene Planning

Selection of 3–5 short animation scenarios
Creation of storyboards for each clip
Definition of timing and key actions

Deliverables:

Storyboard document
Diary: Week 4

Week 5 — Animation Tests

Creation of animation tests (idle, emotion, simple movement)
Testing timing and motion style
Refinement of animation approach

Deliverables:

Animation test clips
Diary: Week 5

Weeks 6–7 — Animation Production

Full animation of short clips
Focus on expressive motion and clarity
Ongoing refinement and feedback

Deliverables:

Draft animated clips
Diary: Weeks 6–7

Week 8 — Refinement

Completion of remaining animations
Visual polish and consistency checks

Deliverables:

Near-final animation series
Diary: Week 8

Week 9 — Platform Optimisation

Optimisation for vertical (9:16) format
Export and testing on mobile devices

Deliverables:

Platform-ready video files
Diary: Week 9

Week 10 — Progress Presentation

Preparation and delivery of progress presentation

Deliverables:

Progress Presentation
Diary: Week 10

Week 11 — Documentation & Finalisation

Completion of technical documentation
Drafting of project report

Deliverables:

Technical document

Diary: Week 11

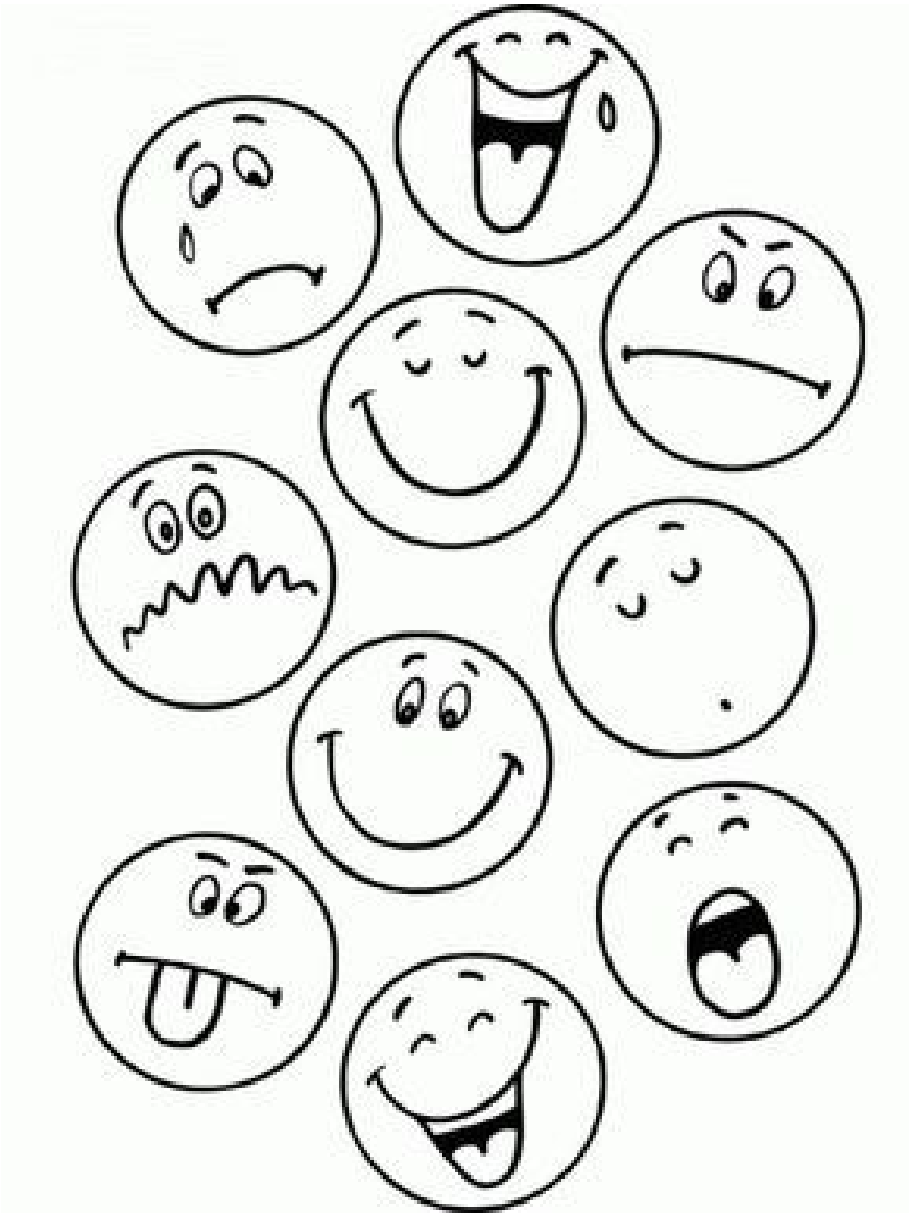
Week 12 — Final Submission

Final submission of animations and documentation

Project reflection and evaluation

Deliverables:

Final project submission

Project report

Diary: Week 12